EUROPEAN UNION (EU)

Origin: The European Union (EU) is a geo-political entity covering a large portion of the European continent. It is founded upon numerous treaties and has undergone expansions from the original, six member-states to 27.

After the Second World War which had devastated the European countries, they expressed their desire to move towards the path of integration. The War had left them totally bankrupt and had hit their economies and human resources hard. The European countries enjoying a dominant position in world politics so far, for example, Great Britain, France and Germany, lost their position and the World was soon dominated by the two superpowers—the United States and the Soviet Union. This period was followed by an extreme superpower rivalry, which came to be known as the **Cold War.** As Europe had always been the centre stage of politics, even after the Second World War and the outbreak of the Cold War, it continued to be the focal point of the superpower politics. Despite the pulls and pressures of the Cold War, there was a desire among the European countries to move towards an integrated Europe, which would work as a bulwark against aggressive nationalism as preached by the Nazi Germany and prevent future holocaust demonstrated in the horrors of war.

The first step towards integration came in the form of a regional arrangement created by the Convention for European Economic Cooperation, signed in Paris on 16 April 1948. The regional arrangement that emerged out of this treaty was called Organization for European Economic Cooperation (OEEC). The chief function of the organization was to act as a coordinating agency of the countries receiving the Marshall Plan aid and it proved to be so useful that it continued to exist even after the Marshall Plan had officially come to an end in December 1951. The Marshall Plan was the primary plan of the United States for re-building and creating a stronger foundation for the countries of Western Europe and repelling communism after World War II. It was within the OEEC that in 1950 the European Payments Union was created to facilitate trade and economic transactions among the member countries. The next boost